

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
KINGS COUNTY

-----X
JOCELYN VELEZ, KIMBERLY SOTO and
JOE ALMEYDA,

Plaintiffs,

-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, DETECTIVE
ALERTE (TAX REGISTRY #929599), POLICE
OFFICER JOHN DOE #1, POLICE OFFICERS JOHN
DOES #2-4 (names and numbers of who are unknown at
present), and other unidentified members of the New York
City Police Department,

Defendants.
-----X

SUMMONS

Index #

Basis of Venue:
Place of Incident

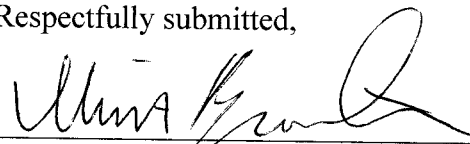
Plaintiffs designate
Kings County
as the place of trial.

To the above named Defendants:

You are hereby summoned to answer the complaint in this action, and to serve a copy of your answer, or, if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance on the Plaintiffs' attorneys within twenty days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service, where service is made by delivery upon you personally within the state, or, within 30 days after completion of service where service is made in any other manner. In case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

DATED: New York, New York
July 30, 2015

Respectfully submitted,



ILISSA BROWNSTEIN, ESQ.

Attorney for Plaintiff

65 Broadway (Suites 813 & 814)

New York, New York 10006

(212) 691-3333

CITY OF NEW YORK: CORPORATION COUNSEL
100 Church Street, New York, New York 10007

DETECTIVE ALERTE (TAX REGISTRY #929599)
79th Precinct, Brooklyn, New York

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
KINGS COUNTY

-----X
JOCELYN VELEZ, KIMBERLY SOTO and
JOE ALMEYDA,

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Plaintiffs, Index #
-against-

THE CITY OF NEW YORK, DETECTIVE
ALERTE (TAX REGISTRY #929599), POLICE
OFFICER JOHN DOE #1, POLICE OFFICERS JOHN
DOES #2-4 (names and numbers of who are unknown at
present), and other unidentified members of the New York
City Police Department,

Defendants.

-----X
Plaintiffs **Jocelyn Velez, Kimberly Soto and Joe Almeyda**, by their attorney, ILISSA BROWNSTEIN,
ESQ., as and for the Complaint herein, alleges upon information and belief as follows:

PRELIMINARY STATEMENT

1. This is a civil rights action to recover money damages arising out of defendants' violation of plaintiffs' rights as secured by the Civil Rights Act, 42 U.S.C. Section 1983, the rights secured by the First, Fourth, and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution and the laws of the State of New York. Plaintiffs were unlawfully arrested by the defendants. Plaintiffs were deprived of their federal constitutional and state constitutional and common law rights when the individually named police officer defendants unlawfully confined plaintiffs, caused the unjustifiable arrest of plaintiffs and malicious prosecution of plaintiffs. Defendants additionally used excessive force in violation of plaintiffs' constitutional rights protected by the Eighth Amendment and the state tort laws.

PARTIES

2. Plaintiff Jocelyn Velez is a citizen of the United States and resident of Brooklyn, New York.
3. Plaintiff Kimberly Soto is a citizen of the United States and resident of Brooklyn, New York.
4. Plaintiff Joe Almeyda is a citizen of the United States and resident of Brooklyn, New York.
5. Detective Alerte (Tax Registry #929599) is and was at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.

6. Detective Alerte (Tax Registry #929599) is being sued in his individual capacity and official capacity.
7. Police Officer John Doe #1 is and was at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
8. Police Officer John Doe #1 is being sued in his individual capacity and official capacity.
9. New York Police Officers John Doe #2-4 are and were at all times relevant herein an officer, employee, and agent of the New York City Police Department.
10. Police Officers John Doe #2-4 are being sued in his individual capacity and official capacity.
11. At all times relevant herein, the individual defendants were acting under color of state law in the course and scope of their duties and functions as agents, servants, employees and officers of the New York City Police Department, and otherwise performed and engaged in conduct incidental to the performance of their lawful functions in the course of their duties. They were acting for and on behalf of the New York City Police Department at all times relevant herein, with the power and authority vested in them as officers, agents, and employees of the New York City Police Department and incidental to the lawful pursuit of their duties as officers, employees and agents of the New York City Police Department.
12. Defendant City of New York is a municipal entity created and authorized under the laws of the State of New York. It is authorized by law to maintain a police department which acts as agents in the area of law enforcement and for which it is ultimately responsible. The defendant City of New York assumes the risks incidental to the maintenance of a police force and the employment of police officers as said risks attach to the public consumers of the services provided by the New York City Police Department.
13. Plaintiffs in furtherance of their State causes of action filed a timely Notice of Claim upon the City of New York in compliance with Municipal Law Section 50.
14. More than thirty (30) days have elapsed since service of said Notice of Claim was filed and the City of New York has failed to pay or adjust the claim.
15. The City of New York held a 50(H) hearing examination of the Plaintiffs on March 20, 2015.

STATEMENT OF FACTS

16. Jocelyn Velez is 36 years old. From 2005-2007, she worked at a deli. From 2012-2013, she worked at a pizzeria. In 2001, she received her Associates Degree in respiratory care from a college in Puerto Rico. Ms. Velez has never been convicted of a crime.
17. Kimberly Soto is 19 years old. She graduated high school in 2013. Since October of 2013, she has been employed at Express Yourself Barista Bar as a barista. She attended one year of college at La Guardia Community College in Long Island City, New York. Ms. Soto has never been convicted of a crime.
18. Joe Almeyda is 36 years old. Since 2012, he has been working as a barber. From 1997-2000, he attended Cora College in Puerto Rico. Mr. Almeyda has never been convicted of a crime.
19. Kimberly Soto is Jocelyn Velez's daughter. Joe Almeyda is Jocelyn Velez's boyfriend.
20. On October 9, 2014, at approximately 5:30am, at 930 Myrtle Avenue, apartment #9, Brooklyn, New York, police officers unlawfully entered and searched Ms. Velez's apartment. During that time, Ms. Velez, Mr. Almeyda, and Ms. Soto were sleeping.
21. Ms. Velez, Ms. Soto and Mr. Almeyda were put in handcuffs and brought into the living room while officers conducted a thorough search of the apartment. During their search, officers broke cabinets and doors while ransacking through every room of her apartment.
22. One officer questioned Ms. Soto and asked if she had any drugs in which she replied no. Ms. Soto told the officer that they were not going to find any drugs in the apartment. Ms. Soto was patted down by a male police officer from below her breasts down to her waist.
23. Upon officers completing their search, they found no contraband.
24. To justify the unlawful search, the police claimed that they had recovered marijuana.
25. Ms. Velez, Ms. Soto and Mr. Almeyda never saw the marijuana that the police claimed they found.
26. Ms. Velez, Ms. Soto and Mr. Almeyda were arrested and brought to the precinct. After six hours, they were released and all received a summons. They were charged with the lowest level of marijuana charge, P.L. 221.05.
27. The police officers in the criminal complaints never indicated where the marijuana was found.
28. Ms. Velez, Ms. Soto and Mr. Almeyda attended one court appearance. At that Court appearance on December 16, 2014, Kimberly Soto learned that her case was administratively/previously dismissed on December 10, 2014.

29. On December 16, 2014, Jocelyn Velez and Joe Almeyda's cases were dismissed because a lab report was never filed.
30. Jocelyn Velez's apartment was destroyed by the police search and she spent approximately \$200 to repair the damages caused by the police search.
31. Kimberly Soto was unlawfully strip searched. Ms. Soto lost one day of wages making \$151 per week. Ms. Soto sought out therapy from her mother's psychiatrist. On account of the incident, she suffers from anxiety and panic attacks. Since the time of the incident occurred, she has been taking antidepressants.
32. Joe Almeyda was incarcerated for approximately six hours.
33. Plaintiffs all filed a notice of claim on December 22, 2014.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

VIOLATION OF PLAINTIFF'S FOURTH AMENDMENT AND FOURTEENTH AMENDMENT RIGHTS

34. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 33 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
35. The individually named defendants who were acting in concert and within the scope of their authority at the NYPD arrested and caused plaintiffs to be imprisoned without probable cause, maliciously prosecuted, and subjected to excessive forced based as well as an unlawful search in violation of plaintiffs' right to be free of an unreasonable seizure under the Fourth Amendment of the Constitution of the United States and to be free of a deprivation of liberty and the right to privacy under the Fourteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

FALSE ARREST AND FALSE IMPRISONMENT

36. Plaintiffs repeat and allege paragraphs 1 through 35 as if fully set forth herein.
37. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute false arrest and false imprisonment under the laws of the State of New York. Defendants intended to confine plaintiffs and, in fact, confined plaintiffs, and plaintiffs were conscious of the confinement. In addition, plaintiffs did not consent to the confinement and the confinement was not otherwise privileged.
38. The individually named defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

39. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

MALICIOUS PROSECUTION

40. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 39 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
41. The acts and conduct of the defendants constitute malicious prosecution under the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution.
42. Defendants commenced and continued a criminal proceeding against plaintiffs.
43. There was actual malice and an absence of probable cause for the criminal proceeding against plaintiffs and for each of the charges for which he was prosecuted.
44. The prosecution and criminal proceedings terminated favorably to plaintiff Kimberly Soto on December 10, 2014 and to plaintiffs Jocelyn Velez and Joe Almeyda on December 16, 2014.
45. Plaintiffs were subjected to a post-arraignment deprivation of liberty sufficient to implicate plaintiffs' Fourth Amendment rights.
46. The individually named defendant Police Officers were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of their employment by the City of New York and the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

INVASION OF PRIVACY (PLAINTIFF: KIMBERLY SOTO)

47. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 46 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
48. Defendants their agents, servants and employees, acting within the scope of his employment, intentionally, willfully and maliciously subjected plaintiff to an illegal and sexually abusive search, and in doing so violated plaintiff's right to privacy.

49. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of his employment by the City of New York and the NYPD which are therefore responsible for their conduct.
50. The City, as the employer of Defendant is responsible for the wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

SEXUAL ABUSE (PLAINTIFF: KIMBERLY SOTO)

51. The plaintiff repeats, reiterates and realleges each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 50 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
52. Defendants their agents, servants and employees, acting within the scope of their employment, intentionally, willfully and maliciously touched plaintiff's stomach down to her waist and in doing so violated plaintiff's right to privacy.
53. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of his employment by the City of New York and the NYPD which are therefore responsible for their conduct.
54. The City, as the employer of Defendant is responsible for the wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

NEGLIGENT HIRING, RETENTION, TRAINING AND SUPERVISION

55. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 56 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
56. The City of New York and its employees, servants and/or agents acting within the scope of their employment did negligently hire, retain, train and supervise the individually named defendants, individuals who were unfit for the performance of NYPD duties.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

FAILURE TO INTERVENE

57. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 56 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
58. Defendants had an affirmative duty to intervene on behalf of plaintiffs, whose constitutional rights were being violated in their presence by other members of the NYPD.
59. Defendants failed to intervene to prevent the unlawful conduct described herein.
60. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiffs were subjected to an illegal search.
61. Defendants were at all times agents, servants, and employees acting within the scope of his employment by the City of New York, the New York City Police Department, which are therefore responsible for their conduct.
62. The City, as the employer of defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

NEGLIGENCE

63. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 62 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
64. Defendants owed a duty of care to plaintiffs.
65. Defendants breached that duty of care by subjecting them to an illegal search.
66. As a direct and proximate cause of this unlawful conduct, plaintiffs sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.
67. All of the foregoing occurred without any fault by plaintiffs.
68. The City, as the employer of the officer defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat superior.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION

NEGLIGENT INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS

69. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 68 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
70. By the actions described herein, the individually named police officer defendants, each acting individually and in concert with one another, engaged in extreme and outrageous conduct, conduct utterly intolerable in a civilized community, which negligently caused severe emotional distress to plaintiffs. The acts and conduct of the defendants were the direct and proximate cause of injury and damage to plaintiffs and violated plaintiffs' statutory and common law rights as guaranteed by the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.
71. As a result of the foregoing, plaintiffs were deprived of liberty and sustained great emotional injuries.
72. The City, as the employer of the defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of respondeat behavior.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

MUNICIPAL LIABILITY UNDER 42 U.S.C. § 1983

73. The plaintiffs repeat, reiterate and reallege each and every allegation contained in paragraphs marked 1 through 72 with the same force and effect as if more fully set forth at length herein.
74. Defendants, collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law, engaged in conduct that constituted a custom, usage, practice, procedure or rule of defendant City of New York, which is forbidden by the Constitution of the United States.
75. The aforementioned customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of defendant City of New York and the New York Police Department included, but were not limited to policies, customs and practices wherein New York City Police officers arrest individuals without probable cause and create false versions of events to justify their actions.
76. The aforementioned customs, policies, usages, practices, procedures and rules of defendant City of New York and the New York Police Department were the moving force behind the violation of plaintiffs' constitutional rights as described herein. As a result of the failure of defendant City of New York and the New York City Police Department to properly recruit, screen, train, discipline, and supervise its officers, including the individual defendants, defendant City of New York has tacitly authorized, ratified, and has been deliberately indifferent to, the acts and conduct complained of herein.

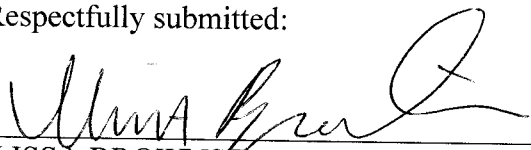
77. The foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, and procedures and rules of defendant. City of New York and the New York City Police Department were the moving force behind the Constitutional violations suffered by plaintiffs as alleged herein.
78. As a result of the foregoing customs, policies, usages, practices, and procedures and rules of defendant City of New York and the New York City Police Department, plaintiffs were unlawfully arrested and prosecuted.
79. Defendants collectively and individually, while acting under color of state law were directly and actively involved in violating plaintiffs' constitutional rights.

WHEREFORE, JOCELYN VELEZ, KIMBERLY SOTO & JOE ALMEYDA, plaintiffs, demand a judgment against the defendants on each cause of action in amounts to be determined upon the trial of this actions which exceeds the jurisdiction of lower courts, inclusive of punitive damages and attorney's fees inclusive of costs and disbursements of this action, interest and such other relief as appropriate under the law.

Dated: New York, New York
July 30, 2014

Respectfully submitted:

By:


ILISSA BROWNSTEIN, ESQ.
Attorney for Plaintiff
65 Broadway
Suites 813 & 814
New York, New York 10006
(212) 691-3333

TO: CITY OF NEW YORK
CORPORATION COUNSEL
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

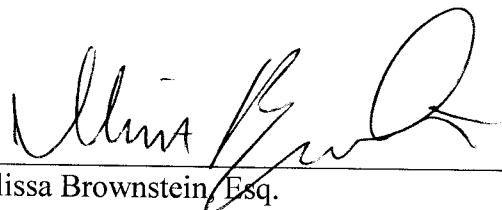
DETECTIVE ALERTE (TAX REGISTRY #929599)
79th Precinct
Brooklyn, New York

ATTORNEY'S VERIFICATION

ILISSA BROWNSTEIN, an attorney duly admitted to practice before the Courts of the State of New York, affirms the following to be true under the penalties of perjury:

I am attorney at the law firm of **ILISSA BROWNSTEIN, ESQ.**, I have read the annexed **VERIFIED COMPLAINT** and know the contents thereof, and the same are true to my knowledge, except those matters wherein which are stated to be alleged upon information and belief, and as to those matters I believe them to be true. My belief, as to those matters therein not stated upon knowledge, is based upon facts, and other pertinent information contained in my files. The reason this verification is made by me and not Plaintiff's is that Plaintiff does not reside in the county wherein I maintain my office.

DATED: New York, New York
July 30, 2015



Ilissa Brownstein, Esq.